

The water cycle

The movement of water around Earth is vital to support life on land. Water evaporates from the oceans to form clouds, which are carried over the land by wind. The clouds drop their water in the form of rain and snow, especially on high land near the sea, and the water drains back into the oceans. Some parts of this cycle are quick, but others take centuries.



WET PLANET

Earth is the only planet in the Solar System with oceans, rivers, and lakes. It also has icy glaciers and polar ice sheets. Some water vapor (gas) in the atmosphere condenses into tiny droplets to form clouds.

Water evaporates from seas and oceans

Clouds carry moisture inland

Water evaporates from lakes

Rivers flow back into the sea

MOVING WATER

The water cycle is powered by the Sun. The water in oceans, lakes, wet ground, and plants evaporates (turns to water vapor) as it is warmed by the Sun's rays. The vapor rises into the air, where it cools and condenses (turns back to liquid), forming clouds. It then falls back to the land as precipitation (rain, hail, or snow), before draining back into the ocean. Then the process begins again.